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4 MILLION FACE MONSTER HIKE TO COUNCIL TAX

Bills could rise by up to **25%** in the most cash-strapped local authorities amid growing threat of bankruptcies

By **Kumail Jaffer**
Political Correspondent

MORE than four million people are facing punishing council tax rises above the maximum normally allowed by law.

Householders in one area could see their bills hiked by 25 per cent – the largest increase in England for two decades.

Seven other struggling councils around the country have proposed huge rises of between 9.99 and 15 per cent from April as they look to exploit a legal loophole – piling pressure on already strained domestic finances.

Local authorities are permitted to raise council tax by up to 4.99 per cent under Government rules. Any larger increase than this would normally have to be approved by a referendum of local taxpayers – something that has never happened because councillors know how unpopular the move would be.

But councils can exploit a loophole with the threat of issuing a Section 114 notice, effectively declaring themselves bankrupt and allowing them to go for higher rises, which would be signed off by Labour's deputy leader Angela Rayner in her role as

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